

The importance of Digit

When I joined Digit back in May 2011, I had the chance to work on the 10-year-anniversary issue in the very first week. Long story short, it was a proper “trial by fire,” encapsulating what it’s like working on our June and December special issues for anyone who hasn’t. That was a herculean undertaking, which resulted in the thickest issue of Digit ever published in print, which had a double-cover and 192 pages. And while at that time it was deeply satisfying for my first month’s accomplishment at Digit, being asked to plan and execute one half of that special issue, the enormity of that achievement has only sharpened in focus in my life’s rearview mirror as the years have gone by.

I don’t remember my very first issue of Digit, although I remember picking it up on my way from college at the railway station. As many readers keep mentioning over the years, I was more interested in checking out the contents of the bundled CDs at first, and got into the magazine quite later. I have no qualms in admitting that I wasn’t a consummate computer geek at the time (don’t think I am one fully yet either, by the way), and Digit helped me with my street cred through college on that front.

Digit’s longevity has been a revelation to many observers and followers of the brand, over the years. Just to give you an idea, Digit has outlived many seminal tech products and services in its quarter century of existence. Digit was born months before the iPod, continuing to outlive the product that defined portable digital music. Apple ended the iPod line after more than 20 years. Orkut was India’s earliest social media platform, before Facebook devoured the world. Google shut it down after 10 years. And the less said about Windows Phone the better, right? A genuinely beautiful mobile OS that couldn’t beat Android and iOS duopoly. Digit watched it launch, peak, memeify, and die. Digit predates the likes of Gmail, YouTube, Facebook, iPhone, every Android phone that ever existed, and then some. The space of this column is too small to recount many other tech products



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Jayesh Shinde
Executive Editor



Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
jayesh.shinde@digit.in | @jshinde

and services that came after, whose birth Digit bore witness. Suffice to say that Digit’s been around the block, and has seen tech’s evolution across the world and here in India better than many others.

Digit has shaped my life in innumerable ways. From close friendships I cherish and value to this day to learning opportunities I wouldn’t have gotten anywhere else, Digit has been a constant. One of the most memorable issues I worked on was in 2015, where we asked tech companies and Digit’s community to donate PC components to the needy. Thanks to all of you and PC peripheral brands, we assembled a few computers and donated it to a charity that worked towards teaching underprivileged girls in Mumbai. Probably the most talked about Digit issue was The Green Issue in 2010, where among the usual fare of booklets and discs readers found themselves sorting through seeds – yes, actual plant seeds were bundled with each issue for readers to plant and nurture. Only Digit could’ve done something like that, not just talk the talk but walk the walk as well – at least a few tiny steps towards making a difference.

That’s always been what’s special about Digit. That ethos will never die, for it continues to define what Digit stands for.

Another thing constantly associated with Digit is how it has constantly evolved to stay relevant with the times, and on that front Manas’ column should give you a glimpse into where Digit is heading next, while still being rooted to its core fundamentals. For added nostalgia, you will enjoy reading Mithun’s column, where he goes on a rare trip down memory lane. And a special treat for all you older readers is an even rarer column by Raaabo aka Robert Sovereign-Smith – flip to page 55 for his memoir of Digit. There’s no better storehouse of Digit memory than Robert, as he was with Digit for 20 years out of 25. Nostalgia pro max!

Lastly, this awesome journey wouldn’t have been possible without all of you, our readers, fans and supporters. Thank you. Here’s to the next 25 years and more! **d**